

Both sides are placed in Group 1 alongside Australia, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and the Netherlands, with their encounter in the T20 showpiece scheduled for June 21 at Old Trafford in Manchester. The two nations have faced each other in 19 T20Is, with India winning 10, South Africa six, and three yielding no result.

Since the 2024 World Cup, India has played four T20I series, against West Indies (home), England (away), Sri Lanka (home), and Australia (away), winning them all. A particularly historic result was beating six-time world T20 champion Australia in its own backyard 2-1, a series triumph Down Under that came after a decade. That the rest of the tour went remarkably abysmally is a conversation for another day.

While the 2024 T20 World Cup came with experimentation en masse, with several debuts handed out, the Indian team one sees today is far more stable, working around a core group. Shafali Verma is back in the thick of things and is set to play her 100th T20I during the series. In the big picture, it is a heartening sign of how regular fixtures for this Indian women's team, which once played a tour a year at times, have now become. Smriti Mandhana has found consistency, but the middle order still needs bolstering.

Towards that end, young Anushka Sharma has been handed a maiden call-up after promising performances in the domestic circuit and in her debut Women's Premier League season, where the 22-year-old offspin-bowling all-rounder impressed for Gujarat Giants by scoring 177 runs, with 124 of them coming in boundaries. Her fluency at No. 3 and scoring intent make her a solid alternative to Harleen Deol, whose strike rate and rotation have often drawn flak.

Another interesting addition to the setup is Anushka's Giants teammate Bharti Fulmali, who last featured for India in 2019. Her ability to accelerate lower down the order is a role she has prolifically essayed for

Vidarbha and the Giants over the years. Consistency has often pushed her out of the reckoning, but the 2025 and 2026 WPL seasons saw her deliver in crunch situations, enough to earn the trust of the management. A partnership between her and Richa Ghosh could help India avoid the occasional drop in momentum in the slog overs, especially if wickets fall.

India has dropped budding keeper-batter G. Kamalini, whose topsy-turvy debut against Sri Lanka showed that her glovework still needs fine-tuning. Uma Chetry returns, and while she is a stable presence behind the stumps, her batting returns are not like-for-like. The issue of Richa not having credible competition to keep her on her toes has been brewing for a few years now, particularly in her role lower down the order, and is something the think tank must address in the larger scheme of things.

With the World Cup in pace-friendly England, India's top priority will be sharpening its seam attack. Kranti Gaud, Arundhati Reddy, and Renuka Singh Thakur are joined by Kashvee Gautam, who will look to shake off injury interruptions and make a strong case for the Indian 15. This is particularly crucial given the careful workload management of Renuka and her limited utility with the bat. Kashvee, a handy batter who can hit long, adds depth to the lower order.

For South Africa, two series wins have come in the five played: against relatively weaker teams like Ireland and Pakistan. With Marizanne Kapp's workload being carefully managed, the bowling has looked a little blunt, allowing standout performances like Fatima Sana's striking across formats and Amelia Kerr's unbeaten 179 in a record-breaking ODI chase.

The South African top order

has been among the runs and will look to build consistency against a probing Indian attack before the World Cup. A fresh addition is Kayla Reyneke, who helped secure thrilling wins against Pakistan and New Zealand. Having led the U-19 setup, the off-spin allrounder will aim to cement her place. Another selection to watch is former captain Dane van Niekerk (**pic, below**), reintegrated as a pure batter. Questions around fitness and competition remain, but coach Mandla Mashimbyi will welcome this as a problem worth having. Onto Kingsmead!



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